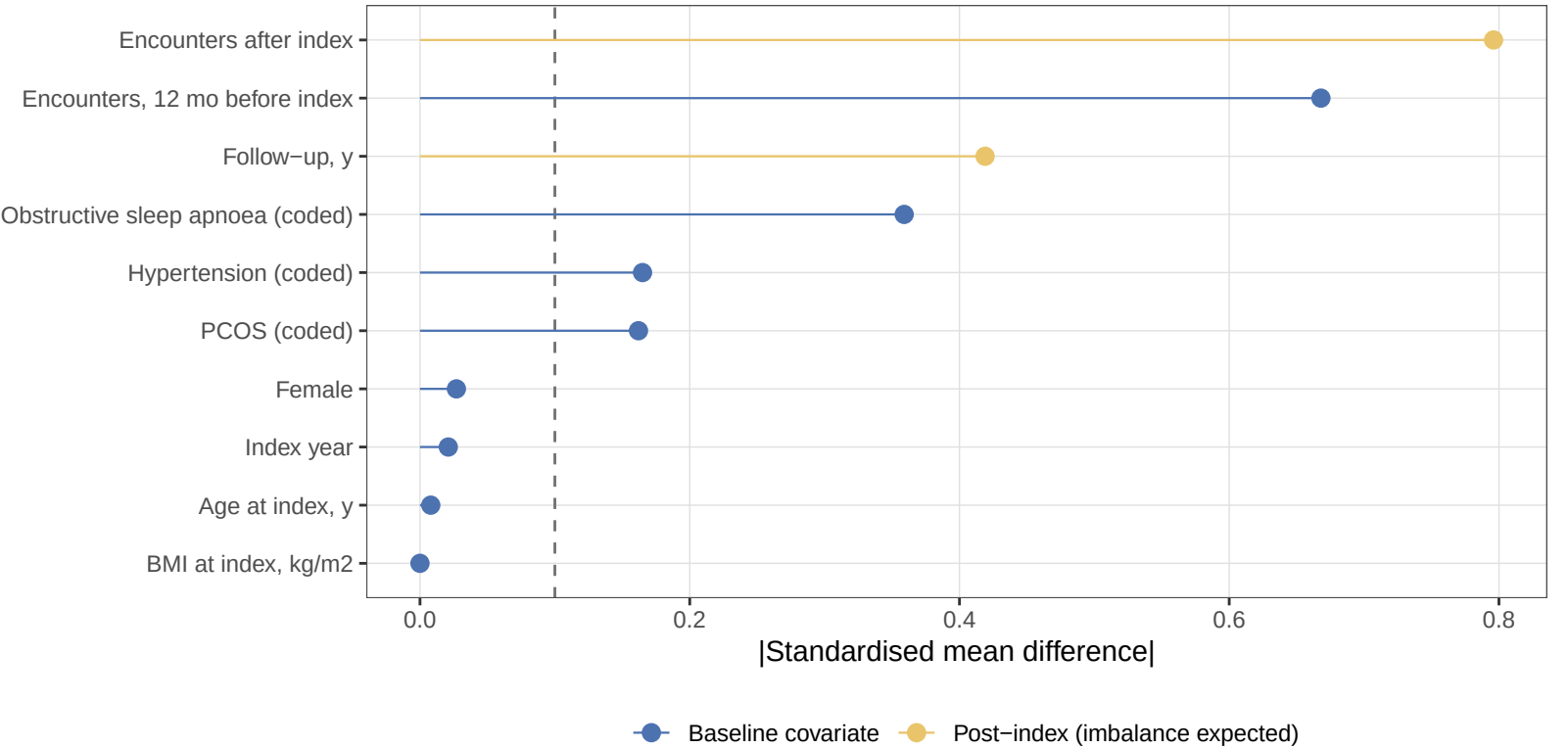


Covariate balance after matching

Dashed line = 0.1. Age, BMI, sex and index year are balanced; comorbidity and healthcare contact are not.



Pre-index encounters remain strongly imbalanced (SMD 0.67) despite the v2.0 rule requiring ≥ 1 control encounter in the prior year. Post-index variables are consequences of exposure.